

One of the most frequent causes of failure is conflict between siblings. How many times do you hear stories about successful families who turn on each other as soon as the patriarch and/or matriarch dies? Once the two key leaders are out of the picture, there's a power vacuum that often leads to trouble.

Siblings who grow up together often carry their childhood issues into adulthood. One child feels neglected. Another feels unappreciated. One enters the family business. Another becomes an artist. Often, the real problem is a dysfunctional heir who causes conflict between siblings. The tabloids find these stories immensely entertaining.

Sibling rivalries can cripple a family organization. Most family fortunes do not survive an extended conflict.

What goes wrong? Nobody really knows. Apparently, some people are doomed to have problems. But we have to believe that many problems can be avoided or resolved. But how?

Business-owning families have more fuel for the family conflict hearth. Some members of the family are likely to work in the business and have more control over the family's wealth. Those on the outside are likely to feel neglected. Often, they will resent the "perks"—cars, travel, salaries—that those in the business give themselves. Or they will disagree about how the business should be managed. Or want to get control of the business for themselves.